Activity A2 - Assess Significance, Risks and Opportunities

Course: Fundamentals of ISO 14001 Environmental Management System (EMS) (TGS-2023037592) Ability: A2 Objective: Assess environmental impacts and EMS risks/opportunities using transparent criteria. Mode: Team analysis with individual evidence submission Suggested time: 60 minutes

Scenario

MEP's departments use different rating scales. Production prioritises cost, Facilities prioritises spill prevention, and Sales prioritises customer carbon requests. Leadership needs one defensible method.

Meridian EcoPack Pte Ltd (MEP) is a fictional Singapore SME with 120 employees producing printed corrugated and fibre-based packaging for regional food, electronics and healthcare customers. Two key customers require evidence of an ISO 14001:2026-aligned EMS and stronger value-chain environmental controls before contract renewal.

Task and expected output

Score MEP's aspects using severity, likelihood, compliance exposure, stakeholder concern and control effectiveness, then test sensitivity.

Produce: A significance matrix, prioritised aspects register and risk/opportunity action shortlist.

Before you begin

- Open a working copy of the Excel workbook; do not overwrite the supplied evidence.
- Allocate a facilitator, evidence recorder, checker and presenter.
- Read every evidence card before making a compliance or significance conclusion.
- If the activity concerns an incident, this is a tabletop exercise: do not handle chemicals or simulate unsafe physical actions.

Decision questions

1. Which criteria make the decision repeatable without pretending that one score is scientific certainty?
2. Which legal or stakeholder triggers should override a low numerical score?
3. How do inside-out environmental impacts differ from outside-in environmental conditions affecting the business?

Detailed procedure

Step 1 - Agree definitions and anchors for severity, likelihood, compliance exposure, stakeholder concern and existing-control effectiveness

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Record the evidence used, the decision made, the responsible owner and any uncertainty in the workbook.

Step 2 - Score independently before discussing to expose inconsistent assumptions

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Step 3 - Apply the stated formula and mandatory-override rules; document the evidence behind each score

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Step 4 - Rank significant aspects and separate inherent significance from residual risk after controls

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Step 5 - Identify at least one risk and one opportunity linked to each priority aspect

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Step 6 - Run a sensitivity check by changing one uncertain score and record whether the priority decision changes

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Record the evidence used, the decision made, the responsible owner and any uncertainty in the workbook.

Evidence to submit

- Completed Activity-A2-Workbook.xlsx.
- One evidence-backed team decision and one documented peer challenge.
- Any assumption or missing source clearly labelled for follow-up.

Acceptance checklist

[ ] Priority aspects are produced by the approved criteria and override rules; scores have evidence/rationale, uncertainties are visible and opportunity actions are not confused with positive impacts.

[ ] Claims are traceable to supplied or cited evidence.

[ ] Assumptions, uncertainty and missing evidence are labelled.

[ ] Owners, due dates and next decisions are included where applicable.

[ ] Legal/compliance interpretations needing competent advice are escalated rather than guessed.

[ ] A peer challenge and response are recorded.

Troubleshooting

- The team cannot agree on a score: return to the criterion anchors and record each evidence-based assumption before averaging or escalating.
- Evidence is missing: do not invent it; record an evidence gap, risk implication, owner and retrieval action.
- A legal requirement is unclear: record the current authoritative source and escalate to a competent adviser or authority channel.
- A conclusion feels obvious: test an alternative explanation and state what evidence would falsify the current view.

Facilitator debrief

Ask each team to defend one priority, control or conclusion using objective evidence. Probe what would change the decision, then connect the work to PDCA and the relevant EMS process rather than clause memorisation.

Files in this activity pack

- README.md and README.pdf - detailed learner procedure.
- Activity-A2-Scenario-and-Checklist.pdf - printable scenario and completion checklist.
- Activity-A2-Workbook.xlsx - editable analysis and submission workbook.

Source and usage note

This fictional training activity paraphrases ISO 14001 concepts and is not legal advice or a reproduction of the standard. Use the organisation's licensed ISO 14001:2026 copy and current authoritative Singapore sources for formal interpretation.